

PRASAD DHAKE

Situated approximately 70 km from Pune, Narayangaon is where my family has been living for the past 20 years. My father worked in a local government hospital till his health deteriorated and he had to leave the service 15 years ago. Having studied in a local school, my awareness regarding various career options was obviously limited. This explained my confusion over which discipline to pursue after completing junior college. Relatives were too keen on a career in medical sciences, but I knew it wasn't my calling. After numerous brainstorming sessions, I decided to pursue computer engineering. I got admission into VJTI, Mumbai (a government engineering college). Having spent four years in the city, I realised various opportunities that were available to a young student. This is



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when I decided to do an MBA and appeared for the CAT exam in my final year of engineering. Much to my surprise, I managed to secure 99.96 percentile in CAT and received calls from all the seven IIMs. During my CAT interview for IIM-A, one of the interviewers, who was originally from Nashik, asked numerous questions about my *taluka* and how it changed over a period of time. My responses in the interviews helped me get offers from all the IIMs. But I opted for IIM-A. The institute provided me with full fee waiver scholarship for further education. For other small expenses, I took a loan.

SAHIL SETHI

Hailing from a small town called Mandi Dabwali in Haryana, the journey to an IIM was unimaginable but not impossible. I had a good academic record and participated in extracurricular activities. My father ran a gift shop but an unfortunate incident in 1995 changed the course of our lives. In December that year, a fire broke out during our school's annual function. About 450 people died in the tragedy but my mother and I had a narrow escape. Left with major injuries in our legs, we underwent several surgeries.



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With no one to look after the business and enormous sum of money being spent on our treatment, the financial position wasn't the same. We moved to Abohar in Punjab in 1997. I got admitted to DAV with full fee concession from the school. After clearing the AIEEE examination in 2003, I secured admission in NIT Bhopal. With no money to pay for the fee, my parents took a loan. I joined MANIT,

Bhopal as a computer engineering student in 2003. I wanted to pursue an MBA after graduation but chose to work for at least two years. This is the reason I joined Verizon in July 2007 in Chennai. But after a year, I decided to prepare for CAT. Finally, I did reasonably well in the exam, securing 99.40 percentile and got calls from all seven IIMs. Following an interview, I became the first person from my town to secure a place at IIM-A.

facilities make it much easier for the students to plan an education, the cost of which can run into lakhs. Almost all the institutes provide some scholarship to the students who come from humble backgrounds. Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad (IIM-A) provides financial assistance to the students coming from economically weaker backgrounds through need-based scholarships and income-linked tuition fee waiver schemes. As a result of the graded fee structure, the institute waived tuition fees of about Rs 5 crore for the 2008 batch and provided free education to 21 students. "The management institutes should be conscious of their obligation to everyone in the society and should not let students forego the opportunity to study for lack of financial resources," says S.K. Barua, director, IIM-A. V.K. Menon, senior director, admissions, career advancement services and financial aid, Indian School of Business (ISB), Hyderabad, couldn't agree more. "It no longer matters where you come from, what counts is the mettle and the acumen of the students. The boundaries have been erased," he says. The ISB offers scholarships ranging from Rs 2 to 5 lakh, corporate scholarships and loan facilities through tie-ups with banks. ■